took selfies with him. Plus, unlike scripted public appearances and stock speeches, Rahul interacted freely and intimately with lakhs of Indians. There are those who describe him as a reluctant politician. But to them I say that no reluctant politician would so happily interact with such a vast ocean of people, embracing them as his family and the land as his home. Rahul did, and also made an entire new generation of Congresspersons bond with India, like India's founders once did. It is only thanks to Rahul that today the Congress boasts a veritable army of patriots who not only love India but also deeply understand it. No other leader in living memory has led so many on a new path through personal example.

Unlike previous yatras, which were directed at a cause or aspiration for one specific section of society, the Bharat Jodo Yatra was unique in that it specifically strived to bring together all of India's diversities in harmony and camaraderie. We saw women, children, youth, sportspersons, professionals, homemakers, the infirm—irrespective of caste, creed, class or ideological inclination. Apart from a generic appeal, the Congress party did not specifically solicit anyone's participation. Yet lakhs of Indians spontaneously came out to walk a few steps with us or just greet us with flowers and give us their favourite food items. This tremendous outpouring of love was a constant balm to the yatris' blistered soles, aching muscles and fatigued bodies. The people strengthened our spirits day after day, and yatri after yatri spoke about the strength they absorbed from the people.

For many (both yatris and bystanders) this was an unforgettable experience unlike anything so far. Many of us have been in the thick of politics for decades, but this was something very different. Yes, the Yatra did serve a political function. But it was also deeply spiritual in nature. Following Mahatma Gandhi's teachings, this exertion of 'atma bal (soul force)' was also forging fresh connections with millions of kindred souls across India. With every step, the Yatra was not only winning the hearts and minds of ordinary Indians, but also imprinting itself on the political perceptions of people who belonged to parties and institutions beyond the contours of the Congress party. People from across the ideological spectrum joined the Yatra in solidarity with what we were attempting to do. Many